

John W. Z. Zhang

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Education

Stanford University

Autumn 2026

Visiting Student Researcher

- Sponsor: Prof. Gary Cox.

London School of Economics and Political Science

Sep 2023 – Autumn 2026

PhD in Economic History

- Fields: Economic History, Political Economy.
- Supervisors: Prof. Patrick Wallis and Prof. Mohamed Saleh.
- Teaching Assistance: Theories and Evidence in Economic History; The Family Economy in History.

London School of Economics and Political Science

Sep 2022 – Nov 2023

MSc in Economic History

- Graduated with Merit (70.88%).
- Dissertation ranked 2nd in the cohort (out of 100+).

University of Bath

Sep 2019 – Jul 2022

BSc (Hons) Economics

- Graduated with First-class honours.
- Dissertation ranked 1st in the cohort (out of 300+).

Job Market Paper

Welfare Retrenchment and Social Unrest

2026

Abstract: Does welfare retrenchment cause social unrest? I study this question using parish-level expenditure on poor relief and data on social unrest in post-Napoleonic England, drawing on the 1818-9 welfare reforms to motivate instrumental variables, regression discontinuity, and event study research designs. The reduced-form analysis finds a causal effect of welfare retrenchment on social unrest between 1816 and 1834, attributable to an exacerbation of relative deprivation that stems from comparisons with higher-expenditure parishes. Simulations from a counterfactual analysis assuming greater accountability for these grievances highlight the importance of equitable social welfare provision in minimising the political costs of austerity.

Next Release

Endogenous Revolutionary Threat

2026

Dataset

Egyptian Parliamentary Speeches, 1924-1952 (with Mohamed Saleh) [🔗](#)

2025

Methods: Computer Vision; Generative AI.

Presentations

- 2026:** Western Economic Association International Annual Conference, Denver; Workshop in Political Economy and Economic History, York; Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy, London; Frontier Research in Economic and Social History Workshop, Berlin; Economic History Society Annual Conference, London; Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2025:** PPE for Public Policy Graduate Conference, London; Graduate Seminar in Economic and Social History, University of Oxford; Economic and Social History Workshop, University of Cambridge; Graduate Economic History Seminar, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2024:** Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.

Other Credentials

Languages: English and Mandarin.

Technical Skills: Julia, MATLAB, Python, QGIS, R and Stata.